To start learning cloud computing, first grasp fundamentals (OS, networking, Linux), then pick a major provider (AWS, Azure, GCP) and learn its core services (compute, storage, security) through free resources like Microsoft Learn and AWS Educate. Build hands-on skills with free tiers and beginner projects (VMs, storage) and consider entry-level certifications like AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner to validate your knowledge and get job-ready.

1. Build Foundational Knowledge

- **Operating Systems:** Get comfortable with Linux basics, as most cloud servers run on it, and Windows.
- **Networking:** Understand core concepts like IP addresses, DNS, and how data moves.
- **Programming/Scripting:** Learn Python and Bash for automation.
- **Databases:** Know relational (SQL) and non-relational (NoSQL) databases.

2. Choose a Cloud Provider & Learn Core Services

- **AWS (Amazon Web Services):** Often recommended for beginners due to market share. Focus on EC2 (compute), S3 (storage), IAM (security).
- **Azure (Microsoft):** Great if you're in a Microsoft-heavy environment. Start with Azure Fundamentals.
- **GCP (Google Cloud Platform):** Strong in data analytics/ML.

3. Learn Key Cloud Concepts

- **Service Models:** Understand IaaS, PaaS, SaaS.
- **Deployment Models:** Public, Private, Hybrid clouds.
- **Core Services:** Compute (VMs, containers), Storage (object, block, file), Networking (VPC, load balancing), Security (IAM, firewalls).

4. Get Hands-On Experience

- **Free Tiers:** Sign up for free accounts on AWS, Azure, or GCP.
- **Projects:** Set up a virtual server (EC2), store files in S3, deploy a simple website.
- **Infrastructure as Code (IaC):** Learn tools like Terraform.

5. Get Certified (Optional but Recommended)

- **Start with Foundational Certs:** AWS Cloud Practitioner or Microsoft Azure Fundamentals (AZ-900).
- **Explore Specializations:** DevOps, Security, Data Engineering.

6. Stay Current & Network

- **Continuous Learning:** The cloud evolves fast, so keep learning.
- **Online Presence:** Build a strong LinkedIn profile showcasing your skills and projects.